

Radiotherapy for pleural mesothelioma

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Radiotherapy for pleural mesothelioma

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays to treat cancer. It is normally given as a series of short, daily outpatient treatments in the radiotherapy department.

Radiotherapy for [pleural mesothelioma](#) may be given to help relieve symptoms, such as pain or swelling. Sometimes it may be given as part of a [clinical trial](#).

You may only need 1 or 2 treatments. Or you may have a course of 5 treatments.

Radiotherapy is carefully planned by a team of experts to do as little harm as possible to healthy cells.

Radiotherapy for pleural mesothelioma does not make you radioactive. It is safe for you to be with other people, including children and pregnant women, during your course of treatment.

Planning your radiotherapy treatment

You will have a hospital appointment to plan your treatment. You will usually have a [CT scan](#) of the area to be treated. During the scan, you need to lie in the position that you will be in for all your radiotherapy treatments.

Your radiotherapy team uses information from this scan to plan the area to be treated.

You may have some small, permanent markings made on your skin. The marks are about the size of a pinpoint. They are made in the same way as a tattoo. The marks help the radiographer make sure you are in the correct position for each session of radiotherapy.

These marks will only be made with your permission. If you are worried about them or already have a tattoo in the treatment area, tell your radiographer. They can discuss this with you.

Radiotherapy treatment sessions

The radiographer will tell you how long each treatment session will take before you start. It usually only lasts a few minutes. Radiotherapy is not painful, but you have to lie still for a few minutes during the treatment.

At the beginning of each treatment session, the radiographer positions you carefully on the couch and makes sure you are comfortable. When you are in the correct position, they leave the room and you are given your treatment. The radiographers can see you during your treatment. Treatment rooms have an intercom, so the radiographers can talk to you as well.

Side effects of radiotherapy

The side effects of radiotherapy for pleural mesothelioma are usually mild. This is because you usually only have a small number of treatments.

Your doctor, radiographer, or nurse will tell you what to expect. Tell them about any side effects you have. There are often things that can be done to help.

Feeling tired is a common side effect of radiotherapy. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest. Gentle exercise like short walks, if you are able to, can give you more energy. You can also ask people to help with everyday jobs if you are feeling too tired. We have more information about [coping with tiredness](#) (fatigue).

Some people may feel [sick](#) (nausea). This is usually mild. Tell your radiographer, nurse or doctor if you feel sick. They can give you anti-sickness drugs to help.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our mesothelioma cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

Kusamura S, Kepenekian V, Villeneuve L, Lurvink RJ, Govaerts K, De Hingh IHJT, Moran BJ, Van der Speeten K, Deraco M, Glehen O; PSOGI. Peritoneal mesothelioma: PSOGI/EURACAN clinical practice guidelines for diagnosis, treatment and follow-up. Eur J Surg Oncol. 2021 Vol, 47(1) pp6-59. [accessed April 2024].

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as ‘you’ so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms ‘men’ and ‘women’ or ‘male’ and ‘female’. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

An anonymous network of people affected by mesothelioma which is free to join. Share experiences, ask questions and talk to people who understand.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

[Get help](#)